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CART 263 SECTION AA

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SAVE THE INTERNET

In the Vanity Fair article "I Was Devasted," Katrina Brooker starts off the article by announcing that "The man who invented the World Wide Web has some regrets. Tim Berners-Lee has seen his creation debased by everything from fake news to mass surveillance" (Brooker 2018). Right at the start of the article, we, as readers, and internet users, immediately feel a sense of worry because if the inventor of the World Wide Web himself admits the Internet is veering towards the wrong path, is the any hope to *Save The Internet*? It was this idea that inspired us for our project and guided the interactions we implemented into it.

While reading the article, we were surprised that Burners-Lee didn't have a profit driven motive when creating the World Wide Web. On the contrary, "[h]e created the web on the basis that the individual would feel empowered, and that not one person would have an advantage over others" (Brooker 2018). Initially the World Wide Web was meant to be a decentralized network meant to empower and help each other, now it has become a money-making machine for the big tech companies to hoard our data and sell it for profit. This idea of using user data for profit is also known as surveillance capitalism as Zuboff analyzes in her book *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism* (Zuboff 2019). The Internet is no longer a place to research, share and learn; it has

become a hub for data extraction for corporations to make unlimited amounts of profit. Contrary to Berner-Lee's motives, the control no longer lies in the hands of users, it lies in the hands of corporations who use platforms to monitor our every move and predict our future behaviour based on the data they collect (Zuboff 2019). The World Wide Web is degrading as time goes on; it is turning into a market that companies use to extract user's behavioural surplus and use against them for profit. It is no longer empowering to the people and as Tim Burners-Lee said, it is becoming "anti-human" (Brooker 2018).

With these ideas of surveillance and the World Wide Web no longer serving its initial purpose of empowering individuals, we decided to make a project that brought to light different aspects we believed made the internet downgrade over time. In fact, the title of our project, *Save The Internet*, highlights the fact that the Internet needs to be saved before takes a turn for the worst. For this project we agreed on representing 3 aspects we believed made the Internet downgrade over time: the increasing surveillance on platforms, the monetization of every useful service and constant advertisements.

Figure 1Start Screen from Save The Internet by Author

First we will talk about how each interactive experience in our project symbolizes the aspects that made the Internet downgrade and then we will discuss the code and tools we used to achieve this project.

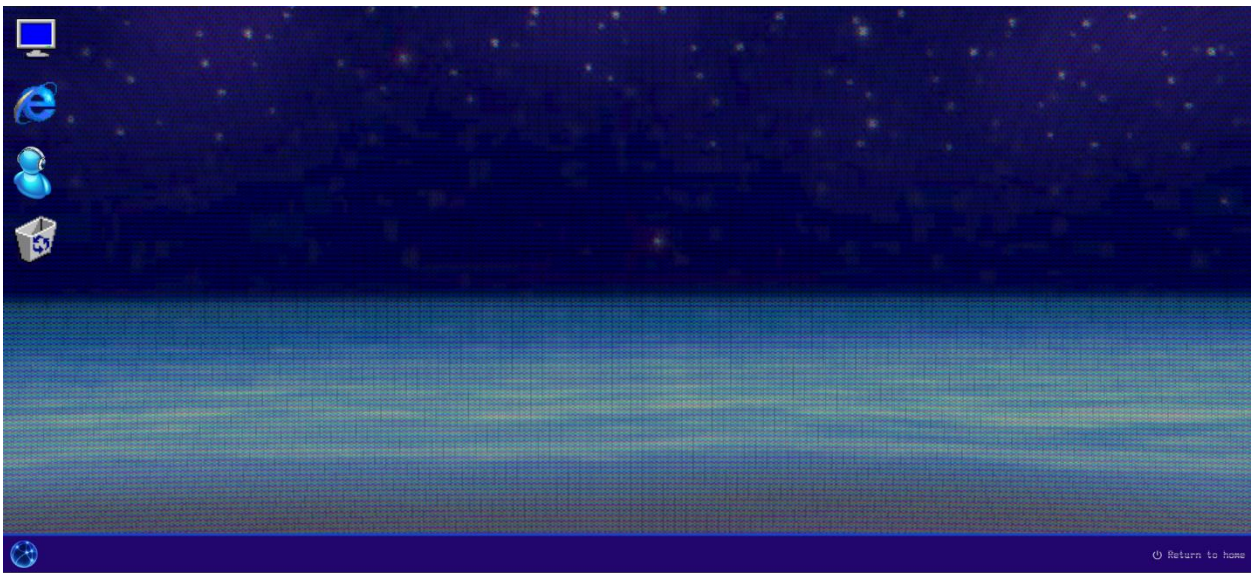

Figure 2 Home Screen from Save The Internet by Author

The image above features the home screen from our interactive web application/page. On this page, the top 3 icons each represent the aspects that we believed were causing the Internet to downgrade. The first icon leads a 3D gallery of cat images standing in a circular arrangement. On top of each cat portrait is a camera that constantly looks at the mouse position. Additionally, there is a video camera frequently tracking the user's facial expression to deduce the user's emotion. As one might guess, this section symbolizes the surveillance aspect of the Internet. We wanted to make users feel vulnerable by tracking their emotions based on their facial expressions and by constantly keeping tabs on their mouse movement through the cameras on top of the cat

portraits. The interactive feature of this section is simple: when the user is happy while facing a certain cat portrait, the image of that specific cat gets added to the user's inventory. The inventory can be accessed by clicking the "inventory" button at the top right of the screen. The user can also reset the cat gallery by being surprised and each cat image will be replaced with a new one.

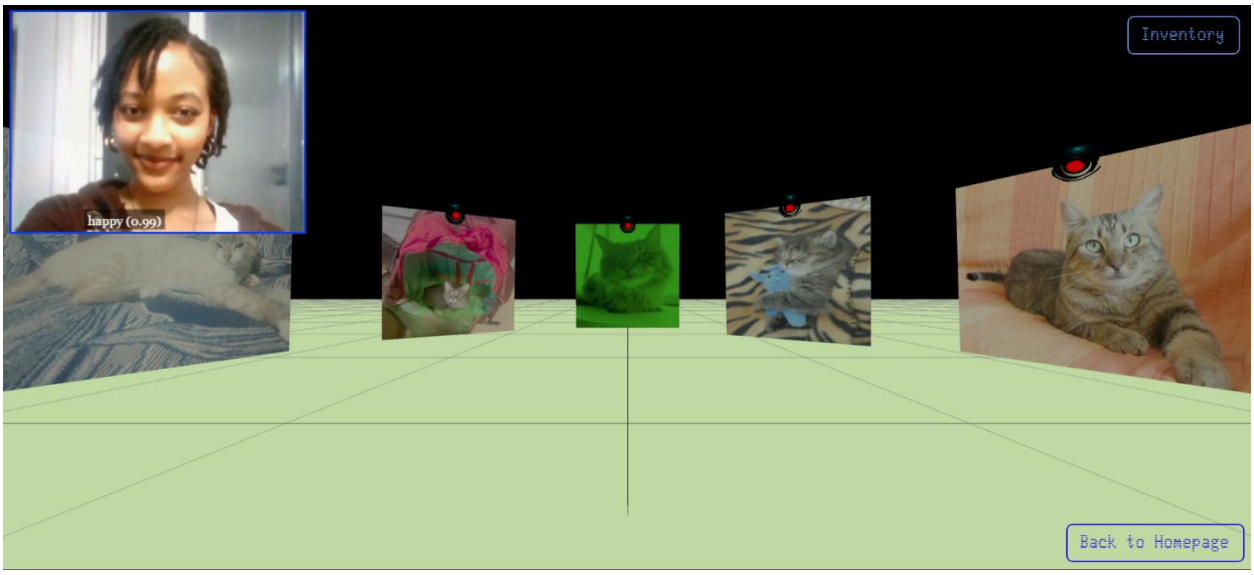

Figure 3 Cat Gallery from Save The Internet by Author

The inventory screen shows the user a carousel layout of all the images they looked at happily. On the surface, the inventory page seems like a place where users can enjoy the images they like, but once users click on the cat images, they are prompted to buy them, symbolizing how surveillance on the Internet is framed to provide more personalized content but in reality it extracts our data to generate profit.

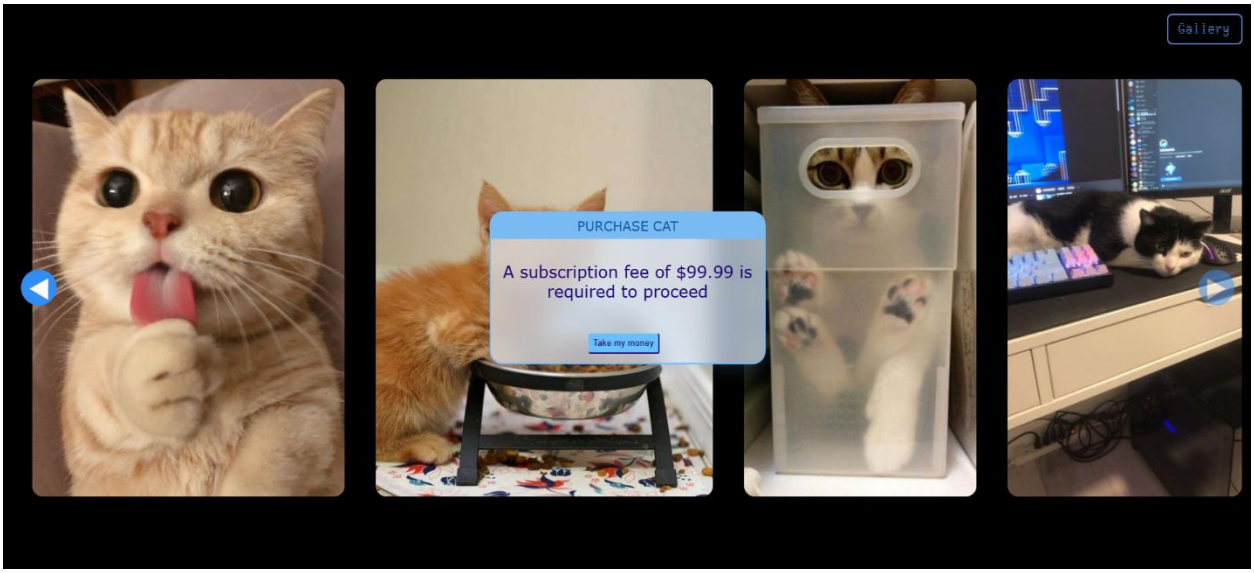

Figure 4 Inventory Page from Save The Internet by Author

Next, we represented the monetization of most useful services on the second icon. When clicked on, the second icon triggers a pop-up search engine screen. Once users type in and press enter to search what they desire, they are interrupted by an error screen that prompts them to subscribe before they can have access to the service. In this interaction, we intended for users to feel interrupted and annoyed at the fact that a simple service such as searching is no longer a free. Although this may not be our current reality, big companies like Google are continuously implementing subscription-based services that were previously free for users. As a result, paid search engines might be closer to our reality than what we might think. That is why we must Save The Internet before it downgrades to that point!

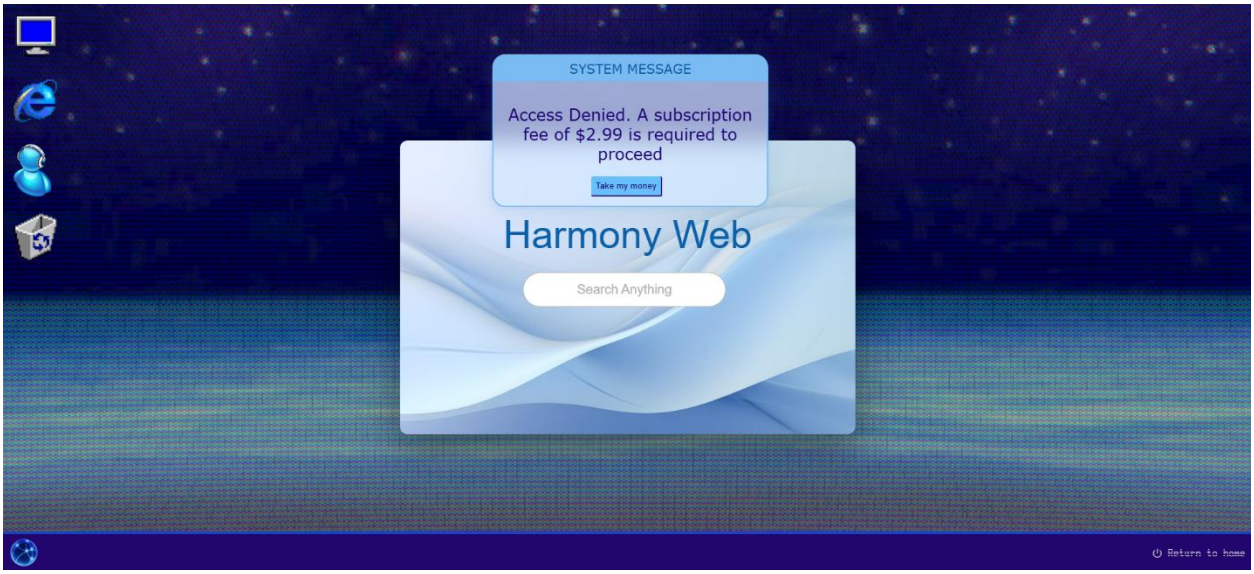

Figure 5 Harmony Web Access Denied Screen from Save The Internet by Author

The next icon, when clicked on, triggers a screen full of images that disorient the user. Even when the images are clicked, they trigger even more images, but once a few seconds pass, they disappear. This interaction represents the increasing number of advertisements we encounter on the Internet, and even when we try to escape them, they always find their way back.

Figure 6 Advertisement Screen from Save The Internet by Author

This project uses a combination of different API's and libraries to achieve the interactivity we were aiming for. Starting off, we used the Node.js library to make our project into a desktop application as well as a web site. We also used the THREE.js library for all the 3D rendering in the cat gallery. We loaded the cat images from the cataas.com API as texture loaders that could be used as a material on the rectangular 3D meshes. We also used the local storage feature to store the cat images from the cat gallery page to the inventory page. Moreover, the draggable pop-up screens used the draggable library from anime.js to simplify our code. Finally, we used a face API by Vincent Mühler on GitHub, to track the user's facial expressions.

Project Page: https://xp30n.github.io/SAVE-THE-INTERNET/

Code : https://github.com/xp30n/SAVE-THE-INTERNET

Bibliography

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